

Should Voting Age Be Lowered to 16?

Name: _____

Date: _____

Australian Curriculum v9.0 Aligned | AC9E6LY04 | Year 6 | Complex Texts, Perspective & Sustained Argument

LEARNING INTENTION

I am learning to analyse complex texts by examining perspective, evaluating evidence and constructing sustained, well-reasoned arguments.

READING STRATEGY

Identify the author's perspective and purpose. Evaluate the quality of evidence. Consider whose voice is missing. Challenge assumptions and construct your own reasoned position.

READ THE PASSAGE — READ IT 3 TIMES!

At 16, Australians can drive, pay taxes, consent to medical treatment and join the armed forces — yet they cannot vote.

This apparent **contradiction** has fuelled growing calls to lower the voting age from 18 to 16.

Advocates argue that young people are directly affected by **policy decisions** on climate change, housing affordability and education — issues with **decades-long** consequences.

Countries including Scotland, Austria and Argentina have already extended voting rights to 16-year-olds, with positive **results**: research shows 16-year-old voters are more **engaged** than first-time voters aged 18-25.

Critics, however, cite **neurological** research suggesting the prefrontal cortex — responsible for **long-term reasoning** — does not fully develop until the mid-twenties.

They also argue that many 16-year-olds lack sufficient **political knowledge** and **life experience** to make fully **informed** voting decisions.

Supporters counter that this argument could equally apply to many adult voters — and that **education**, not exclusion, is the appropriate response.

The debate ultimately asks: at what age does a person deserve a voice in the decisions that shape their future?

VOCABULARY HELPER

contradiction = a situation where two things cannot both be true

advocates = people who publicly support a cause

neurological = relating to the brain and nervous system

prefrontal cortex = the part of the brain responsible for decision-making and planning

informed = having enough knowledge to make a good decision

WARM UP — BEFORE YOU READ

Do you think 16-year-olds should be allowed to vote? Write your initial view in 2 sentences:

A — COMPREHENSION

1. Name 3 things 16-year-olds can already do in Australia:

2. Which countries have already lowered the voting age to 16?

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Year 6 English | Answer Guide & Extension

Aussie Primary
Academy

Name: _____

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Answer Guide (For Parent / Teacher Use)

Warm Up: Accept initial personal view with 2 sentences.

A1. Drive, pay taxes, consent to medical treatment, join the armed forces — any 3. **A2.** Scotland, Austria, Argentina. **A3.** The prefrontal cortex (long-term reasoning) is not fully developed until the mid-twenties. **A4.** This applies to many adults too — education, not exclusion, is the response.

B1. Accept reasoned evaluation: the argument has scientific basis but is weakened by the counter that many adults also have underdeveloped reasoning. Strong arguments include the comparative evidence from other countries. **B2.** The rhetorical question invites the reader to consider the moral dimension — it reframes the debate from neuroscience to rights and fairness.

C: 'Advocates' is more formal and credible than 'people who want' — it implies a principled, organised position. 'Decades-long consequences' emphasises urgency — young people will live with these decisions longest.

High Five! You are a Super Reader! ✓
Colour a star each time you read the passage aloud:



EXTENSION ACTIVITY

Write a formal submission to a parliamentary committee either supporting or opposing lowering the voting age to 16. Use the structure: introduction, arguments, evidence, counter-argument, recommendation.

PARENT TIP

Discuss your own voting experiences. Ask: 'Do you think 16-year-olds are ready to vote? At what age did you feel ready to make political decisions? Why?'

TEACHER TIP

Run a class referendum on the voting age question. Students research, prepare arguments, present to the class and vote. Analyse results and discuss the process of democratic decision-making.

STUDENT REFLECTION

- ☐ I can evaluate the quality of arguments and counter-arguments
- ☐ I can explain the effect of a rhetorical question
- ☐ I can write a structured persuasive speech with a rebuttal